

THE UNDERGRADUATE
STUDENT HANDBOOK



ENGLISH

at Ashoka



WHAT'S INSIDE?

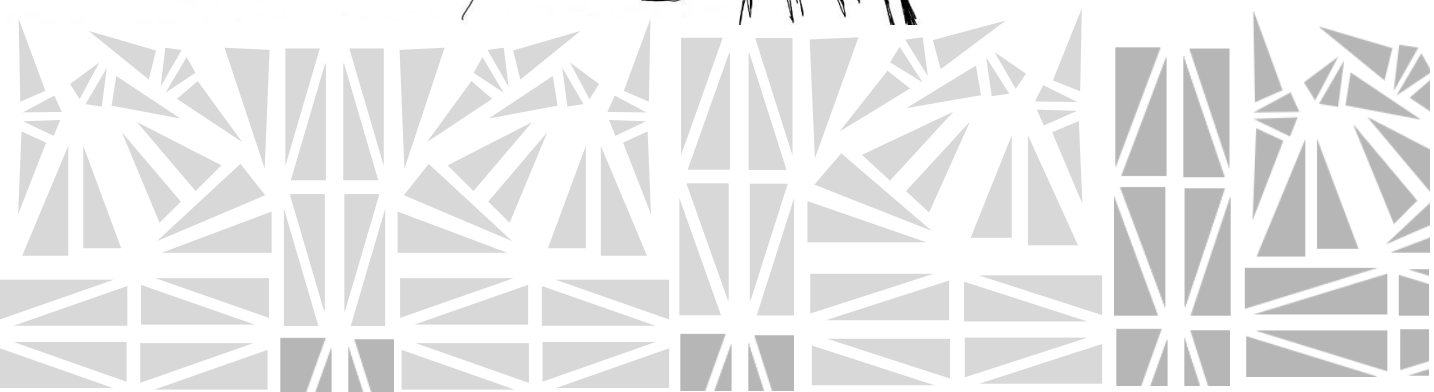
Why English?

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Why English?

The guiding assumption of the English major at Ashoka University is that we all like to travel. Even when we are beset by bad weather, dangerous beasts, visa problems, or even when travelling is impractical with a pandemic looming, we still like to travel and see new worlds. Some of these worlds might be frightening; many might involve thinking thoughts that we never have before; a few will allow us to recognise ideas that we have had all our lives.

Nothing facilitates these journeys better than literature. Whether it is by reading books written by unfamiliar authors or thinking through the intricacies of an idea, literature challenges our minds to expand, grow, travel. All literature involves an imaginative movement outside the bounds of the familiar. Our courses map such movements across genre—theory, fiction, poetry, drama, film—cultures, and languages. Literatures in translation are a vital component of our curriculum as we seek to put in conversation texts that have been divided by boundaries of various kinds.

English at Ashoka takes seriously knowledge of canonical Western texts like Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, Shakespeare's plays, and Brontë's novels, Indian texts like Mahasweta Devi's short stories, Amruta Patil's graphic novels, and Bollywood films, as well as world classics like *A Thousand and One Nights*, Greek tragedies, and Audre Lorde's poetry. The English Major and Minor at Ashoka put disciplines in dynamic dialogue with each other, ensuring both specific knowledges and a more general ability to think.

Our aim is to be globally literate while also taking cognizance of our rootedness in India. We offer a wide range of courses that will prepare the Ashoka English graduate for a variety of careers in higher education, law, advertising, and any field that requires an agile mind able to traverse across borders.

"To read is to be ecstatic. As the etymology of the word—ekstasis—suggests, reading takes us out of ourselves and out of our place. Through imagination, empathy, and self-questioning, by learning to trespass into unfamiliar times and inhabit unfamiliar spaces, and via translation and theory, studying literature allows us to examine our world and ourselves—which, as 'ecstatic' also suggests, can be great fun."

Mandakini Dubey, Assistant Professor of English and Critical Thinking
Ph.D. Duke University
Nineteenth-century English literature and culture; Romanticism;
Empire and Colonial Discourse; Literary Theory; Affect Theory



"Literature is about life and our ways of being human. It is a practice of freedom that opens us to the power of language. Literature is comfortable with uncertainty, border crossing, and has no fear of contradictions."

Abir Bazaz, Associate Professor of English
Director of the PhD Programme in English
Ph.D. University of Minnesota
South Asian literatures in English; Existentialism; Comparative Mysticism;
Violence; Cinema Studies; Intellectual History of Islam in South Asia

"To make a life in literature is to live as a 'bhasha karmi', a language worker. An understanding of language, its behaviour and its power, its ruptured blood vessels and its intestines—that is why we come to writing, to create a language of intimacy that rejects the readymade."

Sumana Roy, Associate Professor of Creative Writing
Ph.D. University of North Bengal
Literature on the non-human; Provincial literatures;
Cultures of close-reading; 'Minor' forms of writing





Curriculum

The English department offers six core courses, of which two are gateways, required for a student to begin studying literature, and four are survey courses, which track the movement of English literature from eighth-century England to postcolonial nations in the twenty-first century. We also offer an array of electives in exciting sub-fields. Additionally, our faculty teach different sections of the two Foundation courses, *Literature and the World* and *Great Books*.

Gateway Courses

ENG 1001 'Forms of Literature' (Offered every Spring)

We begin with introducing literary history as articulated through different genres: epics, tales, poetry, prose, drama and newer forms: lyric poetry, films, graphic novels and so on. Rather than as fixed categories or lists of unvarying characteristics, we examine literary forms as both shaped by *and* as shaping their social and historical contexts, i.e., their material foundations. In doing so, the course will engage with 'form' as it configures our relationship with literature, but also beyond.

ENG 1002 'Introduction to Literary Theory' (Offered every Monsoon)

'Literary theory' is notoriously difficult to define, not least because it houses writing from various disciplines, each with their own take on 'theory'. Derived from the Ancient Greek '*theoria*'—etymologically connected with sight, close viewing and, theatre—theory is bound up with literature. In this course, students ready theory by stepping back from fiction to think about the big questions of reality, language, identity, power, desire, history—broadly, the self and the world. Students of this course will be enmeshed with these questions not by reading theory as a 'lens' for literary texts but by reading theory as texts in their own right, alive with contradiction, style and writing that demands close reading. Along the way, you will ask: What counts as literature? What is the role of history in the production of literature? Does literature reflect reality or create it? What are the politics of reading? This course will allow you to survey theoretical schools while also muddying the distinctions between them.



Survey Courses

ENG 2001 'Early British Literature' (Offered every Monsoon)

The multicultural quality of the British archipelago, shaped by arrival and migration, suggests something conversational and transformative about the notion of what is 'British' (unlike the more singular word 'English', for instance). It is in that spirit that this course surveys Early British texts and the cultural conditions of their production between, roughly, 700 and 1700 AD. The course will look at pre-modern and early modern literature, reading authors such as Chaucer, Shakespeare, Spenser and Milton and texts such as the epic poem *Beowulf*, Mandeville's travel writing and *The Book of Margery Kempe*, among others.

ENG 2002 'Literature and the Age of Empire' (Offered every Spring)

Literature and the Age of Empire considers texts written between the 17th and 20th century under the sign of imperial expansion. But it also considers the very notion of 'Empire' as literary—a fictional construction which, through writing of the time, allows us to also tackle attendant questions of travel, of economy, of sexuality, of science and of space. The course looks at dramas, novels, poems, pamphlets, speeches and essays, starting with texts such as *Aureng-zebe* or *Oroonoko* and closing with *A Passage to India*.

ENG 2003 'Indian Literatures' (Offered every Spring)

What are the origins, scope, and variety of literature produced in India? Was there always an *India*? Beginning with these questions, students think through moments of literature-making in the Indian scenario, examining the contexts that inform textual constructions of the nation, as well as the "nation's" ideas of the life and the world.



ENG 3001 Postcolonial Literatures

What is the relevance of reading postcolonial literature in contemporary classrooms? Is it somewhat redundant to do so? This course begins with such questions but moves beyond, to read certain postcolonial literary texts as not only physically rooted in material spaces, but also as embodying the spirit of such locations, often untranslatable and un-exportable. Here, we will come together to see if the universal can be sought in the most sensory embodiment of the particular, including stories from “backward and provincial” spaces, or if it is to be identified more easily in the symbolism reinforced by colonial and neocolonial languages of modernity.

OR a 3000-level course under the Modern Literatures bucket (of which, one or more courses were offered every semester from Spring 2025 onwards. **This bucket applied only for students in the UG '25, UG 2023 and UG 2024 batches between Spring 2025 and Spring 2026)**

The Modern Literatures bucket covers a broad range of 3000-level courses, each focusing on specific themes and questions aimed at investigating contemporary literatures (i.e. covering texts from 1900 and onwards).



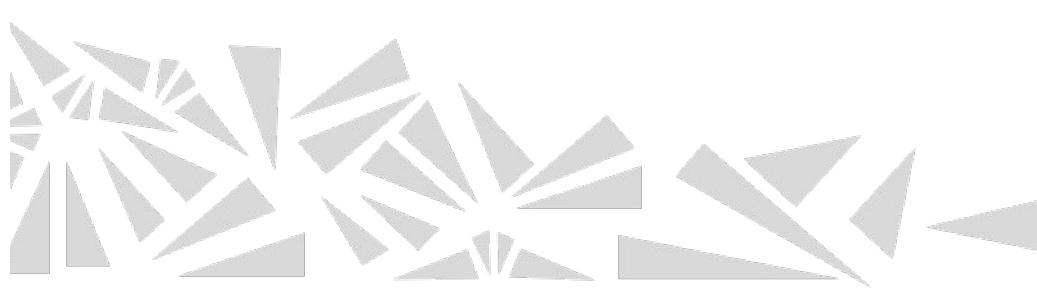
Electives

2000-level Introductory Electives are introductory courses to various fields and methodologies of literary study. They may consider certain forms, as in *Introduction to Rhetoric*, *Fictions of the List* or *Introduction to Drama and Theatre*. They may consider literary formations, such as ‘Masala Shakespeare’ or translated Tamil literature. They may also begin to open students up to specialised fields, as in *Digital Humanities*, *Performance Studies*, *A Literary History of Utopia* or *Introduction to Children’s Literature*.

Critical Thinking Seminars are electives that train students in academic writing. Recent offerings include *Detecting Writing*, *Landscapes and Cartographies of Bigotry* and *English Vinglish*. Critical Thinking Seminars are sometimes taught by senior research scholars in the department.

3000-level Seminar Electives are specialist courses designed for English majors and minors. Only students who have taken the gateways can take these courses. Recent offerings include *Existentialism in Literature, Philosophy and Film*, *Novel Worlds*, and *Reading Theory*.

Graduate Courses are 4000-level seminar courses reserved for the undergraduate students who pursue the major in their 4th year. They will study these intensive courses along with MA and PhD students. Recent offerings include *Apparitions of Macbeth*, *The Global Medieval*, *Reading Psychoanalytic Writing* and *Dil ka batwara: the Cinematic Partition*.



“Once we have some sense of how fundamentally at odds we are with ourselves—the lesson brought to us by literary theory—then we can begin to appreciate that we are texts requiring to be read. And once we grasp the ungraspable slipperiness of ourselves as texts, then we can begin to fathom the politics of reading itself. This is what studying literature is about.”



Madhavi Menon, Professor of English
 Director of the Centre for Studies in Gender and Sexuality
Ph.D. Tufts University
 Queer Theory; Literary Theory; Renaissance; Shakespeare;
 Sexuality; Politics of Identity and Desire



“It is easy to imagine that environmental crises are geophysical problems belonging first and foremost to the realm of science. But that thinking ignores the complex interplay between natural systems and human culture. The very word “ecology” was coined in 1866 comes from the Greek word oikos - household - and carries with it notions of balance, harmony, and stability. These are not empirical concepts, but rather questions of language, aesthetics, and ideology. As with most any other topic that matters to humans, we can’t think about environmental questions without also considering the reality of human histories and cultures.”

Alexander Phillips, Assistant Professor of English
 Director of the MA Programme in English
Ph.D. Cornell University
 Ecocriticism and Environmental Humanism; Realism; Frankfurt School and
 Critical Theory; Nineteenth to Twenty-First Century German Literature

“Literature provides possibilities of lives we have not lived, but also ones we shouldn’t be living. The study of literature is also the most meaningful way to understand the daunting expanse and depth of language; for language is much too important to be left to linguists! The failure of language in its effort to keep up with experience characterises translation; which is not a gesture achieved, but forever in a state of compounding approximations.”



Rita Kothari, Professor of English
 Co-Director of the Ashoka Centre for Translation
Ph.D. Gujarat University
 Caste and Communalism; Bollywood; Indian literatures;
 Translation Studies; Partition; Border Studies

The English Major: 3-year Programme

(For the UG '25 Batch and Onwards)

To pursue a 3-year major in English, a student must complete **13 courses**.

2 Gateway Courses:	Forms of Literature Introduction to Literary Theory
4 Survey Courses:	Early British Literature Literature and the Age of Empire Indian Literatures Postcolonial Literatures (OR any other Modern Literatures* course. This applies only for the UG '25, UG 2023 and UG 2024 batches)
7 Elective Courses:	1 x Critical Thinking Seminar** 2 x 2000-level elective 3 x 3000-level electives 1 x 2000/3000-level elective (those students intending to do the 4-year programme must take a 3000-level elective here)

Notes on the 3-year Programme:

* One or more courses under the Modern Literatures bucket will be offered every semester. These will be 3000-level courses, and will count towards the survey requirement; alternatively, these courses can also count toward elective requirements, provided the survey requirement has been fulfilled by the student or does not apply to them.

** Once the CTS requirement has been fulfilled, any further CT courses taken will count as regular 2000-level electives.

A third-year student can take **ONE 4000-level elective** in place of a 3000-level requirement. They will need to seek permission from the instructor in advance.

Students can take a maximum of **3 cross-listed courses** (courses taught by faculty of other disciplines) as electives that count towards their major. *[Note: courses originating from the English department and cross-listed with other departments count as regular courses for the English major; courses originating in other departments that are cross-listed with English count as cross-lists.]*

An ideal time-table for an English major pursuing the 3-year Programme looks like this:

Semester 1	Semester 2	Semester 3	Semester 4	Semester 5	Semester 6
	Forms of Literature	Literary Theory Early British Literature	Indian Literatures Literature and the Age of Empire	Postcolonial Literatures	
		1 Critical Thinking Seminar and 6 electives, distributed as per the student's preference			

Students are welcome to follow this timetable or reorganize the order in a manner of their choosing. Since the **gateway courses introduce the discipline** to students, it is always wise to take them first. If you are confused about how to organise your courses, please reach out to the English Representatives.



The English Major: 4-year Programme

The 4th-Year

This is the year in which the students become members of a teaching and scholarly community. They will have the opportunity to:

- **TA for courses** and be mentored by an English professor in questions of pedagogy through the Teaching Practicum. Bear in mind that Teaching Practicums are pursued by *4th-year English Majors* only.
- **Take 4000-level electives** at the graduate level, alongside MA and PhD students.
- **Take Graduate Proseminars** and **write a research thesis**.

TA-ships: Fourth-years pursuing an English major will have the opportunity to TA for one course per semester as a part of the credit requirement. Students can choose not to TA, but it is **strongly recommended** that they take the Teaching Practicum. The Practicum consists of working with a professor to provide **logistical and pedagogic support** for their courses. This entails circulating readings, running PPTs, managing Classroom pages, and meeting with students for office hours. The professor also provides **mentorship** on classroom management, syllabus design, and other aspects of teaching. *[Note: A pure English Major in their fourth year can TA for only one course per semester.]*

Thesis: In the 4th year, students have the option of writing a research thesis under the supervision of an advisor. This experience is crucial preparation for any students planning to do higher studies in English or any other discipline. They are expected to reach out to their preferred advisor (professors aligned with an area the student wishes to research) as they approach 4th year. The thesis is worth 12 credits in total, spread across the two semesters of the fourth year. These credits are *not* counted within the maximum credit limits in each semester.

Graduate Proseminars: The proseminars are meant for students writing theses on the English track. They will aid in preparing for a thesis in the Monsoon, and writing a dissertation in the Spring; the thesis will be a part of these courses. The two proseminars are worth 8 credits in total, which will count toward the maximum credit limits in each semester.

To pursue a **4-Year English Major without a thesis**, a student must complete **18 courses**:

- 2 **Gateway** Courses: Forms of Literature
 Introduction to Literary Theory
- 4 **Survey** Courses: Early British Literature
 Literature in the Age of Empire
 Indian Literatures
 Postcolonial Literatures (**OR any other Modern Literatures* course. This applies *only* for the UG '25, UG 2023 and UG 2024 batches**)
- 12 **Elective** Courses: 1 x Critical Thinking Seminar[#]
 2 x 2000-level electives^{**}
 3 x 3000-level electives
 2 x 3000 or 4000-level electives[^]
 2 x 4000-level electives[^]
 2 x Teaching Practicums^{^^}/4000-level electives

To pursue a **4-Year English Major with a thesis**, a student must complete **18 courses with 12 additional research credits**:

- 2 **Gateway** Courses: Forms of Literature
 Introduction to Literary Theory
- 4 **Survey** Courses: Early British Literature
 Literature in the Age of Empire
 Indian Literatures
 Postcolonial Literatures (**OR any other Modern Literatures* course. This applies *only* for the UG '25, UG 2023 and UG 2024 batches**)
- 12 **Elective** Courses: 1 x Critical Thinking Seminar[#]
 2 x 2000-level electives^{**}
 3 x 3000-level electives
 1 x 3000 or 4000-level elective[^]
 1 x 4000-level elective[^]
 2 x Proseminars^{***}
 2 x Teaching Practicums^{^^}/4000-level electives

If a student chooses to do a thesis, they will receive 12 additional research credits (6 in Monsoon + 6 in Spring), counted *outside* the maximum credit limits of each semester.

Notes on the 4-year Pure English Major:

* One or more courses under the Modern Literatures bucket will be offered every semester. These will be 3000-level courses, and will count towards the survey requirement; alternatively, these courses can also count toward elective requirements, provided the survey requirement has been fulfilled by the student. **This applied only for the UG '25, UG 2023 & UG 2024 batches.**

** Any **1 language-course** can fulfill the requirement for a maximum of 1 2000-level elective. This might include courses in Persian (HIS-1011, HIS-1012), in Elementary Sanskrit (SAN-1001, SAN-1002, SAN-2001) or in Mandarin (CHI-1101, CHI-1102, CHI-2101).

*** The Proseminar courses are mandatory for students pursuing a thesis in English. Those not doing the thesis may replace the Proseminars with regular 4000-level electives.

Once the CTS requirement has been fulfilled, any further CT courses taken will count as regular 2000-level electives.

^4000-level courses are graduate-level seminars, typically offered only for fourth-years and graduate students. Any third-year student interested in taking a 4000-level course will need written permission from the course's instructor and can have it fulfill the 3000-level elective requirement. This can only be done for **one course** in **any one** semester of the student's third-year.

^^A student will only earn Teaching Practicum credits if they are a teaching assistant for a course that originates in the English Department—not if they are a teaching assistant for a cross-listed course.

A maximum of **4 credits** of Independent Study Modules (ISMs) can count towards the Pure English Major. At most, **one** 4-credit ISM will correspond to an elective taken at the level at which the ISM was registered.

Students can take a maximum of **3 cross-listed courses** (courses taught by faculty of other disciplines) as electives that count towards their major.

*[Note: courses originating from the English department and cross-listed with other departments count as regular courses for the English major; courses originating in other departments that are cross-listed with English count as cross-lists. For example, ENG-3501/MS-3491 'Studies in Film: The Queer Eye' **will not** count as a cross-listed course towards the English major, since it originates in the English Department. MS-2410/ENG-2803 'How To Read A Film', which originates in the Media Studies Department, **will** count as a cross-list.]*

An ideal time-table for an English major pursuing the 4-year Programme looks like this:

Semester 1	Semester 2	Semester 3	Semester 4
	Forms of Literature	Literary Theory Early British Literature	Indian Literatures Literature and the Age of Empire
		Other electives and a CTS, as per the student's preference	

Semester 5	Semester 6	Semester 7	Semester 8
Postcolonial Literatures		Proseminar in Thesis Preparation 4000-level electives / Teaching Practicum	Proseminar in Thesis Writing 4000-level electives / Teaching Practicum
Other electives and a CTS, as per the student's preference			

Students are welcome to follow this timetable or reorganize the order in a manner of their choosing. Since the **gateway courses introduce the discipline** to students, it is always wise to take them first. If you are confused about how to organise your courses, please reach out to the English Representatives.

The English Minor



The Minor and the Concentration facilitate students of other disciplines to pursue their interest in literary study.

A Minor in English requires a student to complete **6 courses**.

2 **Gateway** Courses:

Forms of Literature
Introduction to Literary Theory

2 of 4 **Survey** Courses:

Early British Literature
Literature in the Age of Empire
Indian Literatures
Postcolonial Literatures (OR any other
Modern Literatures* course. This applies
only for the UG '25, UG 2023 and UG 2024
batches)

2 **Elective** Courses:

1 x 2000/3000-level elective
1 x 3000/4000-level elective

Notes on the Minor:

* One or more courses under the Modern Literatures bucket will be offered every semester. These will be 3000-level courses, and will count towards the survey requirement; alternatively, these courses can also count toward elective requirements, provided the survey requirement has been fulfilled by the student or does not apply to them. **This applied only for the UG '25, UG 2023 & UG 2024 batches.**

Students doing the Minor **over 3 years instead of 4** will need written permission from the professor to take a 4000-level course.

Students can take a maximum of **1 cross-listed course** (courses taught by faculty of other disciplines) as an elective that counts towards their minor.

[Note: courses originating from the English department and cross-listed with other departments count as regular courses for the English student; courses originating in other departments that are cross-listed with English count as cross-lists.]

The English Concentration

The Minor and the Concentration facilitate students of other disciplines to pursue their interest in literary study.

A concentration in English requires a student to complete 4 courses.

1 of 2 Gateway Courses: Forms of Literature or
Introduction to Literary Theory

Any 3 English courses
(These 3 courses can include the other gateway course, any of the survey courses, and the electives*)

Notes on the Concentration:

*Some 3000-level electives will have ENG-1002 'Introduction to Literary Theory' as a prerequisite. In that case, students can take it either as a part of their gateway requirement, or as one of their other 3 courses.

Students can take a maximum of 1 cross-listed course (courses taught by faculty of other disciplines) as an elective that counts towards their concentration. *[Note: courses originating from the English department and cross-listed with other departments count as regular courses for the English student; courses originating in other departments that are cross-listed with English count as cross-lists.]*

"One of the unique things we do in creative writing at Ashoka University is to forge a relationship with reading in our mother tongues. In India we have the happy advantage of usually being fluent in at least two languages, each of which has a rich literature of its own. Through our courses in translation, students not only read (and listen and imagine) closely in their mother tongue, but they also polish their own art of writing by translating these texts into English. In the process, they add more gems to the treasure trove of literatures in translation from around the world."

Arunava Sinha, Professor of Practice in Creative Writing
Chair, Department of Creative Writing and Co-Director of the Ashoka
Centre for Translation
Translator of *Chowringhee*, *Seventeen*, *Ten Days of the Strike*;
Books Editor, *Scroll.in*
Translation; Literary Journalism; Graphic Narratives



"A study of the most fundamental function of language is persuasion. Persuasion and argumentation are the foundations of rhetoric, a field as ancient as it is contemporary, as humanistic as is rooted in business communication. My special interest is the nature of political discourse, and the various means of persuasion—whether shady or respectable—that inspire politicians in their quest for votes."

Subhashree Chakravarty, Associate Professor of English and Writing
Ph.D. *The Ohio State University*
Rhetoric and Critical Theory; Discourse Analysis; South Asian literatures;
Race Studies; Immigration; Religion and Secularism in South Asia



"The study of literature teaches us that we do not think merely in the form of categories and concepts but more significantly, and overwhelmingly, using figures: metaphors, metonyms, symbols, allegories and so much more. The study of literature is then an attempt to follow the life of language as it manifests itself in the finite-infinite that is the text."

Huzaifa Omair Siddiqi, Assistant Professor of English
Director of Undergraduate Academic Advising
Ph.D. *Jawaharlal Nehru University*
German Idealism, Romanticism, Phenomenology and
Deconstruction, Urdu poetics and prose, Marxist Aesthetics,
Subcontinental Philosophy



The Interdisciplinary Major *in English and Creative Writing*

The English and Creative Writing programme combines scholarly training in literature with exposure to the practice of writing in the various literary genres: poetry, fiction, and non-fiction. Here, critical thinking and creative writing complement one another. Coursework will constitute of English courses focusing on literary history and theory, forms of literature, a selection of literature electives; as well as a multi-genre introductory course in creative writing, courses on the craft of writing, and genre-specific workshops where a community of student-writers come together to read and respond to each other's work.

The 3-year Programme

Students need to take **15 courses** to pursue this Interdisciplinary Major over 3 years.

9 English:

2 **Gateway** Courses:

Forms of Literature
Introduction to Literary Theory

3 of 4 **Survey** Courses:

Early British Literature
Literature in the Age of Empire
Indian Literatures
Postcolonial Literatures (OR any other Modern Literatures* course. This applies **only** for the UG '25, UG 2023 and UG 2024 batches)

6 **Elective** Courses:

1 x Critical Thinking Seminar[#]
3 x 2000/3000-level electives** (with a **maximum of two 2000-level electives**)

6 Creative Writing:

2 **Gateway** Courses:

Reading for Writing
Introduction to Creative Writing



1 Craft of Writing Course:	1 x 2000-level Craft Course***
2 Workshops:	2 x 3000-level Workshops
1 Additional Course:	<i>For students writing a Creative Writing Thesis, this must be the 3000-level 'Publishing Seminar'</i> <i>For other students, this can be 1 additional Workshop</i>

The Undergraduate Creative Writing Thesis:

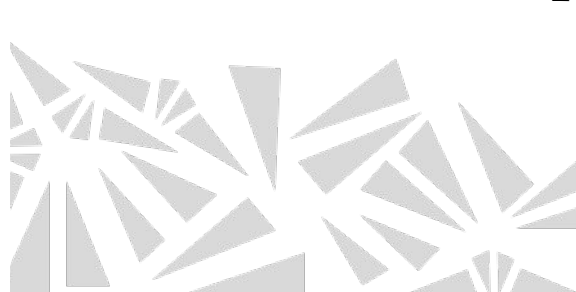
The thesis is a creative and critical project undertaken over a year in a genre of your choosing. The **creative component** requires you to produce a body of creative work and the **critical component** is a self-reflexive supplement ruminating on your process and choices (of theme, genre, etc).

The 4-year Programme

A student pursuing a 4-Year Major in English and Creative Writing has the option of doing so with or without a thesis. The thesis may be on the **English** track or on the **Capstone Creative Writing** track. In the case of an ENG thesis, they must complete **20 courses**; in the case of a CW capstone, they must complete **22 courses**:

13 English:

2 Gateway Courses:	Forms of Literature Introduction to Literary Theory
3 of 4 Survey Courses:	Early British Literature Literature in the Age of Empire Indian Literatures Postcolonial Literatures (OR any other Modern Literatures* course. This applies only for the UG '25, UG 2023 and UG 2024 batches)
8 Elective Courses:	1 x Critical Thinking Seminar [#] 2 x 2000-level electives** 3 x 3000-level electives 2 x 4000-level courses <i>For students writing an English Thesis, these 2 4000-level electives must be 2 x Proseminars</i> <i>For students writing a capstone Creative Writing thesis <u>or</u> not writing a thesis at all, these can be 2 x 4000-level electives, one of which can be a Teaching Practicum</i>



7 or 9 Creative Writing:



2 Gateway Courses:	Reading for Writing Introduction to Creative Writing
1 Craft of Writing Course:	1 x 2000-level Craft Course***
2 Workshops:	2 x 3000-level Workshops
1 Additional Course:	<i>For students writing an Undergraduate Creative Writing Thesis, this must be the 3000-level 'Publishing Seminar'</i> <i>For other students, this can be 1 additional Workshop</i>
1 Critical Elective:	1 x 4000-level Critical Elective^^

If you choose to do either an English thesis in your fourth year, you will receive 12 additional research credits (6 in Monsoon + 6 in spring), counted *outside* the maximum credit limits of each semester.

If you choose to do a *capstone* Creative Writing thesis in your fourth year, you will receive additional research credits counted *outside* the maximum credits limits of each semester. You will also take 8 additional credits, counted *within* the maximum credit limits of the semester. These will be two **extra** courses: 1 more 4000-level **Critical** Elective and the 4000-level 'Publishing Seminar'

What is the difference between the Undergraduate Creative Writing Thesis vs. the Capstone Creative Writing Thesis for a 4-year ENGCW student?

The Undergraduate CW Thesis: This thesis is a creative and critical project undertaken over a year in a genre of your choosing. The **creative component** requires you to produce a body of creative work while the **critical component** is a self-reflexive supplement ruminating on your process and choices (of theme, genre, etc). The total length is approximately **8000** words (6000 for the creative component + 2000 for the critical component). If a student is interested in a fourth-year *Capstone Creative Thesis*, the Undergraduate CW Thesis is a prerequisite for it, which must be done in the third-year alongside the 3000-level version of the 'Publishing Seminar'.

The Capstone CW Thesis: This is a thesis of approx. **15,000** words done in the fourth year. To write this thesis, the student must have completed the Undergraduate CW Thesis and the 3000-level of the 'Publishing Seminar' in the third year. Student will then take the 4000-level of the 'Publishing Seminar' as well as a Critical Elective, alongside the fourth-year thesis.



Notes on the Interdisciplinary ENG CW Major:

* One or more courses under the Modern Literatures bucket will be offered every semester. These will be 3000-level English courses, and will count towards the survey requirement; alternatively, these courses can also count toward elective requirements, provided the survey requirement has been fulfilled by the student or does not apply to them. **This applied only for the UG '25, UG 2023 & UG 2024 batches.**

Any 1 **language-course can fulfill the requirement for a maximum of 1 2000-level English elective. This might include courses in Persian (HIS-1011, HIS-1012), in Elementary Sanskrit (SAN-1001, SAN-1002, SAN-2001) or in Mandarin (CHI-1101, CHI-1102, CHI-2101).

Once the CTS requirement has been fulfilled, any further CT courses taken will count as regular 2000-level electives.

^4000-level courses are graduate-level seminars, typically offered only for fourth-years and graduate students. Any third-year student interested in taking a 4000-level course will need written permission from the course's instructor and can have it fulfill the 3000-level elective requirement. This can only be done for **one course** in **any one** semester of the student's third-year.

***As a general rule, any Creative Writing course with the course-code CW-2XXX, counts as a Craft of Writing course.

^^A Critical Elective is a 4000-level elective. Some examples of critical electives are: CW-4405 'Is There A Modern Indian Literature' and CW-4701 'Workshop in Creative and Critical Writing'.

Students can take **cross-listed courses**, courses taught by faculty of other disciplines, as electives, but **they can only count 2 such electives towards their ID major.**

[Note: courses originating from the English department and cross-listed with other departments count as regular courses for the English student; courses originating in other departments that are cross-listed with English count as cross-lists.]

The Interdisciplinary Major *in English and Media Studies*

If one were to follow the possibilities that Jacques Derrida's suggestion "there is nothing outside of the text" offers us, then the study of media is fruit ripe for the picking. It is through the study of the *text* in its many forms – print journalism, music, film, photography, social media and museums – that invigorates the creative mode of the interdisciplinary program, as well as its self-reflexive critical investigations. It is because of their shared investment in critical nuance (through courses like *Media, Culture & Society* or *Travel Writing*, for instance) and careful attention to precise detail (as in *Newswriting and Reporting* or *How to Read A Film*) that these disciplines are meaningfully married.

The 3-year Programme

To pursue this interdisciplinary major in 3 years, a student needs to take 15 courses.

9 English:

- | | |
|------------------------|---|
| 2 Gateway Courses: | Forms of Literature
Introduction to Literary Theory |
| 3 of 4 Survey Courses: | Early British Literature
Literature in the Age of Empire
Indian Literatures
Postcolonial Literatures (OR any other Modern Literatures* course. This applies only for the UG '25, UG 2023 and UG 2024 batches) |
| 4 Elective Courses: | 1 x Critical Thinking Seminar [#]
3 x 2000/3000-level electives**
(with a maximum of 2 2000-levels) |

6 Media Studies:

- | | |
|---------------------|---|
| 1 Gateway Course: | Media, Culture and Society |
| 5 Elective Courses: | 1 x Media Production Course***
1 x 2000-level Media Studies Course
1 x 3000-level Media Studies Course
2 x any Media Studies courses |

The 4-year Programme

A student pursuing a 4-Year Major in English and Media Studies has the option of doing so with or without a thesis. (The thesis may be on the English track or on the Media Studies track.) In either case, they must complete **20 courses**:

13 English:

- 2 **Gateway** Courses: Forms of Literature
Introduction to Literary Theory
- 3 of 4 **Survey** Courses: Early British Literature
Literature in the Age of Empire
Indian Literatures
Postcolonial Literatures or any Modern Literature Course*
- 8 **Elective** Courses: 1 x Critical Thinking Seminar#
2 x 2000-level electives**
3 x 3000-level electives
2 x 4000-level courses
For students writing an English Thesis, these 2 4000-level electives must be 2 x Proseminars
For students writing a Media Studies thesis or not writing a thesis at all, these can be 2 x 4000-level electives, one of which can be a Teaching Practicum

7 Media Studies:

- 1 **Gateway** Course: Media, Culture and Society
- 1 **Methods** Course: Methodological Approaches to Understanding Media^^
- 5 **Elective** Courses: 1 x Media Production Course***
1 x 2000-level Media Studies Course
1 x 3000-level Media Studies Course
2 x any Media Studies electives of your choice.

If you choose to do a Thesis in either English or Media Studies in your fourth year, you will receive 12 additional research credits (6 in Monsoon + 6 in spring), counted *outside* the maximum credit limits of each semester.

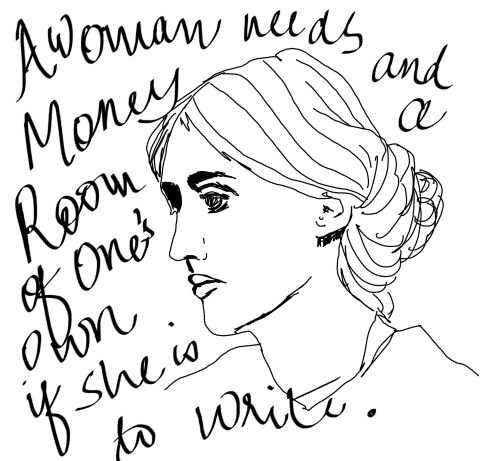
A note on the Media Studies Thesis

A minimum CGPA of 3.6 is required to undertake a capstone thesis with the Media Studies Department. The Media Studies Thesis can take any of the following forms:

A Multimedia Thesis: This can be a **video documentary** with a minimum length of **30 minutes** OR an **audio documentary**, with a minimum length of **30 minutes**. Either must be accompanied by a note of **2500 words** addressing the concept, context, methodology and justification for the creative component.

A Journalism Thesis: This can be a **long-form magazine** article of **5000 - 6000** words OR a series of **3** articles of **2000** words each, within a single research theme. Either must be accompanied by a note of **2500 words** addressing the concept, context, methodology and justification for the creative component.

A Research Thesis: Students can write a **research-led** thesis with the Media Studies Department if they have agreement from an eligible advisor to advise the thesis and submit a preliminary proposal of **1,500 words** by 31st July. The student can engage in preliminary work on the thesis, if they wish to do so, under supervision of the advisor. The annotated bibliography and the final proposal should be submitted at the end of Monsoon semester of the year the student writes their thesis. The thesis submission and the thesis defense presentation will take place at the end of Spring semester. The student is expected to be in contact with their thesis advisor throughout both semesters and to work closely with their advisor. The final thesis should be no more than **15,000 words**.





Notes on the Interdisciplinary ENGMS Major:

* One or more courses under the Modern Literatures bucket will be offered every semester. These will be 3000-level English courses, and will count towards the survey requirement; alternatively, these courses can also count toward elective requirements, provided the survey requirement has been fulfilled by the student or does not apply to them. **This applied only for the UG '25, UG 2023 & UG 2024 batches.**

Any 1 **language-course can fulfill the requirement for a maximum of 1 2000-level English elective. This might include courses in Persian (HIS-1011, HIS-1012), in Elementary Sanskrit (SAN-1001, SAN-1002, SAN-2001) or in Mandarin (CHI-1101, CHI-1102, CHI-2101).

Once the CTS requirement has been fulfilled, any further CT courses taken will count as regular 2000-level English electives.

^4000-level courses are graduate-level seminars, typically offered only for fourth-years and graduate students. Any third-year student interested in taking a 4000-level course will need written permission from the course's instructor and can have it fulfill the 3000-level elective requirement. This can only be done for **one course** in **any one** semester of the student's third-year.

***A list of **media-production** courses are released by the Media Studies Department every semester.

^^Methodological Approaches to Understanding Media is a 4000-level course, offered in Monsoon, typically taken in the fourth year.

Students can take **cross-listed courses**, courses taught by faculty of other disciplines, as electives, but **they can only count 2 such electives towards their ID major**. *[Note: courses originating from the English department and cross-listed with other departments count as regular courses for the English student; courses originating in other departments that are cross-listed with English count as cross-lists.]*

"Reading pre-modern literature compels us to enter into conversation with the unfamiliar. Through such transtemporal encounters, we find common ground with a past that once seemed strange and, at the same time, locate the unfamiliar within ourselves."

Alexandra Verini, Associate Professor of English
Ph.D. University of California, Los Angeles

Medieval and Early Modern literature and visual culture; Women's literature; Gender and Sexuality; Friendship; Religion; Utopia



"At first glance, performance seems antithetical to literature: it is a non-written embodied thing that disappears before it reaches the archive. But look at it differently: performance extends literature's vast reach to the ways in which individuals and communities appear, disappear, and reappear in the ordinary moments of everyday life. By theorizing this ordinary, embodied, and ultimately irreducible aspect of human experience, performance widens the scope of literature and the humanities."

Vivek Narayan, Assistant Professor of English and Performance Studies
Director of the Department Colloquium Series

Ph.D. Stanford University

Theatre and Performance Studies; Postcolonial Theory; Dalit Studies; Transnational Solidarities; Care Ethics; Performance-Making



"Susan Sontag wrote that 'the writer must be four people: 1) The nut, the obsédé, 2) The moron, 3) The stylist, 4) The critic. 1 supplies the material; 2 lets it come out; 3 is taste; 4 is intelligence.'" In the classroom we nurture these different facets of literary thinking. We all enjoy a good story — literature is a home for laughter, wonder, and surprise; but its most remarkable gifts include an expanded capacity for boredom and perplexity, an access to different experiences of time and ways of being, and a love of difficulty: a passion for that which challenges us and forces us to change in order to meet it. Along with all the pleasures it offers, literature provides an opportunity to learn patience, fortitude and painstaking devotion to our objects of study. It teaches us to be sensitive readers and listeners, to be affected and addressed by local and global events. Among the disciplines of study, literature is unusually accommodating and hospitable: it forecloses no possibilities, and encourages a roving curiosity."

Eesha Kumar, Assistant Professor of English
Ph.D. New York University

Comparative literature, Philosophy, South Asian studies;
Questions of Form, Poetics, Translation, Intellectual History;
Enumeration, Classification, Taxonomy



The Interdisciplinary Major *in English and Performing Arts*

The centrality within the English curriculum of drama (classical and modern, Western and Indian) and theories of performance and performativity (Butler, Austin, Goffman, the Natyashastra) makes the discipline a welcome fit with Performing Arts.

The 3-year Programme

To pursue this interdisciplinary major in 3 years, a student needs to take 15 courses.

6 Performing Arts:

2 **Compulsory** Courses:

Developing Performance Skills
Performing Arts Practices

4 **Elective** Courses:

The other 4 courses may be chosen from any of the other performing arts courses on offer during a particular semester.

2 Interdisciplinary Major Gateways:

2 **Gateway** Courses:^^

Introduction to Theatre and Drama (**OR a substitute for it, as indicated at the start of each year**)
Performance, Performativity, and Embodied Knowledges: Introduction to Performance Studies

7 English:

2 **Gateway** Courses:

Forms of Literature
Introduction to Literary Theory

3 of 4 **Survey** Courses:

Early British Literature
Literature in the Age of Empire
Indian Literatures
Postcolonial Literatures (**OR any other Modern Literatures* course. This applies only for the UG '25, UG 2023 and UG 2024 batches**)

2 **Elective** Courses:

1 x Critical Thinking Seminar[#]
1 x 2000/3000-level elective**

The 4-year Programme

A student pursuing a 4-Year Major in English and Performing Arts has the option of doing so with or without a thesis. (The thesis may be on the English track or on the Performing Arts track.) In either case, they must complete **20 courses**:

7 Performing Arts:

- 2 **Compulsory** Courses: Developing Performance Skills
Performing Arts Practices
- 4 **Elective** Courses: The other 5 courses may be chosen from any of the other performing arts courses on offer during a particular semester.

2 Interdisciplinary Major Gateways:

- 2 **Gateway** Courses:^^ Introduction to Theatre and Drama (**OR a substitute for it, as indicated at the start of each year**)
Performance, Performativity, and Embodied Knowledges: Introduction to Performance Studies

11 English:

- 2 **Gateway** Courses: Forms of Literature
Introduction to Literary Theory
- 3 of 4 **Survey** Courses: Early British Literature
Literature in the Age of Empire
Indian Literatures
Postcolonial Literatures (**OR any other Modern Literatures* course. This applies only for the UG '25, UG 2023 and UG 2024 batches**)
- 6 **Elective** Courses: 1 x Critical Thinking Seminar
1 x 2000-level elective
2 x 3000-level electives
2 x 4000-level courses
- For students writing an English Thesis, these 2 4000-level electives must be 2 x **Proseminars***
*For students writing a Performing Arts thesis or not writing a thesis at all, these can be 2 x **4000-level electives**, **one** of which can be a **Teaching Practicum***



If you choose to do a Thesis in either English or Performing Arts in your fourth year, you will receive 12 additional research credits (6 in Monsoon + 6 in spring), counted *outside* the maximum credit limits of each semester.

Notes on the Interdisciplinary ENGPA Major:

* One or more courses under the Modern Literatures bucket will be offered every semester. These will be 3000-level English courses, and will count towards the survey requirement; alternatively, these courses can also count toward elective requirements, provided the survey requirement has been fulfilled by the student or does not apply to them. **This applied only for the UG '25, UG 2023 & UG 2024 batches.**

Any **1 language-course can fulfill the requirement for a maximum of 1 2000-level English elective. This might include courses in Persian (HIS-1011, HIS-1012), in Elementary Sanskrit (SAN-1001, SAN-1002, SAN-2001) or in Mandarin (CHI-1101, CHI-1102, CHI-2101).

Once the CTS requirement has been fulfilled, any further CT courses taken will count as regular 2000-level English electives.

^4000-level courses are graduate-level seminars, typically offered only for fourth-years and graduate students. Any third-year student interested in taking a 4000-level course will need written permission from the course's instructor and can have it fulfill the 3000-level elective requirement. This can only be done for **one course** in **any one** semester of the student's third-year.

^^**Introduction to Drama and Theatre** may be substituted for another course as indicated by the Department of English each year. In this case, the substituted course can count towards the interdisciplinary gateway requirement, instead of the elective requirement. **Introduction to Performance Studies** will likely be offered every *other* spring semester. Students are expected to plan accordingly.

Students can take **cross-listed courses**, courses taught by faculty of other disciplines, as electives, but **they can only count 8 such electives towards their ID major**. *[Note: courses originating from the English department and cross-listed with other departments count as regular courses for the English student; courses originating in other departments that are cross-listed with English count as cross-lists.]*



Some general notes for the ID Majors, Minors and Concentrations:

Cross-listed courses for the ID Majors, for Minors and for Concentrations:

For the interdisciplinary majors (**ENGMS**, **ENG CW** and **ENGPA**), one cross-listed course cannot count for two different requirements in either parts of your major (i.e., for both an English requirement AND a Media Studies, Creative Writing, *or* a Performing Arts requirement). A cross-listed course can only meet ONE requirement for your ID major. In case you are planning for a cross-listed course to count towards the requirement for the parent department (i.e., an English-origin course being used to meet an English elective requirement), it does NOT count as a cross-list. In case you are planning for a cross-listed course to count towards the requirement for the cross-listed department (i.e., an English-origin course being used to meet an Media Studies, Creative Writing, or a Performing Arts elective requirement OR a course originating in the Media Studies, Creative Writing or a Performing Arts department being used to meet an English elective requirement), then it will count as a cross-listed course.

The above rule does not apply to cross-listing between your major department and your *minor* or *concentration* department. One course can meet the requirement for BOTH your major and your minor/concentration as long as the cross-list limit is abided by. That being said, the course will only be counted once to compute whether you've met your degree requirements, which is separate from major/minor/concentration requirements.

Independent Study Modules for the ID Majors, Minors and Concentrations:

Independent Study Modules (ISMs) with the English Department do NOT count towards the elective requirements for ID majors (**ENGMS**, **ENG CW** or **ENGPA**), for English minors or for English concentrations. ISMs taken by these students will count towards your open credits.

“Every story is a migrant. We are conditioned to think in terms of “national literatures” and “national languages,” but the truth is that stories and words rarely if ever spring from one soil. The act of communication is always a movement across a border. Every utterance reconfigures words spoken before; every tale reimagines stories told elsewhere; every reading moves “me” toward what I am not. This is the promise of literature — to move us.”

Jonathan Gil Harris, Professor of English
Ph. D. University of Sussex

Shakespeare; Global and Indian Shakespeares; Early Modern literature;
Migration and cultural contact; Silk Road Cultures; Global Jewish History



“Studying literature at Ashoka is not a march through the ‘canon’ but a three or four-year experience of reading both widely and closely, in all kinds of texts, in order to better imagine how literature works in the world. Studying medieval literature, in particular, may sound like a conscientious exercise in building ‘background’ for the reading of works written closer to us in time. But in fact its very remoteness—the challenge it presents of understanding its language, diction, and historical and cultural interactions—denies us the opportunity to ever read passively, compels us always to be energetic, critical, and questioning participants in a very lively textual world.”

Aparna Chaudhuri, Assistant Professor of English
Deputy Head, Department of English
Ph.D. Harvard University

Vernacular Theology; Medieval English Literature; Global Medieval Studies;
Medieval and Early Modern Religion; History of Domesticity

“To think both in the creative and the critical registers is vitally important when we read like a writer; after all, it is such thinking that breathes method and magic into our writing.”

Arpita Das, Associate Professor of Practice of Academic Writing;
Faculty, Creative Writing
Academic Writing, Publishing History and Practices, Popular Culture,
Urbanism, Sexuality and Gender, Women in Public Spaces





Campus Engagement

English Colloquiums

The English Colloquium Series is an initiative organized and run by the undergraduate and graduate students of the Department of English. It is aimed at expanding and enriching the scope of our conversations as students in the humanities and social sciences. We invite scholars, artists and intellectuals across a range of disciplinary formations and interests to support our vision towards interdisciplinary thought-practice.

Epigraph, the Literary Society

Falling directly under the English department, Epigraph, the Literary Society is founded and run by students who organise talks, lectures, workshops, and events about the literary in and out of the classroom. The activities of the society are proof that the literary is not limited to academic, and that the academic is as intoxicating as the informal. From a speaker series of disability studies and a workshop on graphic narrative to treasure hunts and book exchanges, Epigraph strives to create a space to engage with literature in more than one way.

The English Mixers

The English Mixer is open to all students interested in exploring the discipline. On this exciting day, all the headiness of literary study takes the form of fun and banter. It is a welcoming space for students at any stage of engagement with English, with food and activities mixed in. The mixer offers the chance to meet faculty and peers across batches in an informal, social setting.



Annual Confabulation

The Annual Confabulation is an English-only event that is jointly hosted by the department and the department's student representatives. Students of English, undergraduates and graduates, come together to meet their faculty in a new avatar outside their classroom, teaming up and playing literary games.

The Literary Theory Salon

The Literary Theory Salon is a student-led initiative, organised by the English Representatives, that creates a shared space for engagement with theoretical texts. It is oriented toward strengthening the habits of reading, discussion, and critical reflection that underpin the study of literature. The Salon reads pieces of theory that students may or may not have read in their courses, with an eye for sustaining conversation around the reading and writing of theory.

Annual Department Conference

The student conference, hosted by the Department of English, was conceived as a forum for intellectual exchange among postgraduate students and emerging scholars. The conference foregrounds student research and aims to foster dialogue across institutions, disciplinary approaches, and stages of academic work. It is co-organised by faculty members and a conference committee consisting of undergraduates, MA students and PhD scholars.

What comes after English at Ashoka?

The skills that are learnt in the literature classroom are much sought after in a variety of institutions and professions. While many of our students decided to further study literature at the graduate level, some of our students have also gone to work in **media organisations, publishing houses, law firms, public policy think-tanks, public relations firms, corporations, and educational institutions.**

“I work as an executive producer at Star Plus. As the custodian of the shows I work on, I am involved in helping finalize the broad story, scripting and editing episodes and marketing my shows across all platforms. This entails a lot of critical reading and discussion to decide the journeys our protagonists will take and how the story will move forward. My favourite part here is working together with different people to ideate stories. Just like the English classroom, there is no possibility of claiming an idea or working individually—we all chime in with our thoughts and feed off one another to collectively!”

Nayani Kushal Goyal, ASP 2018
Executive Producer, Star Plus India

“English at Ashoka taught me to read critically and with grace. The department’s brilliant faculty encouraged me to ask difficult questions about the world and our place in it without expecting easy answers—a skill that has proven to be invaluable at my current position as a PhD student in English and Comparative Literature at Columbia University. As mentors and pedagogues, the department has shown me what instruction, support, and even at times, tough love can look like. As a result, I feel better equipped to be a more equitable and engaging facilitator with my own students. English at Ashoka has created a vibrant community of scholars who are passionate about nuanced and exciting ways of thinking and being in the world, and for that, I’m grateful!”

Kaagni Harekal, ASP 2019
Ph.D. Candidate, Columbia University



“Prof. Harris sometimes reminds us that the Latin derivation of ‘educate’ is to ‘lead away’. This etymology is a helpful reminder that an education doesn’t have to be a hierarchical instruction-giving with a predestined lesson. The four years I spent with Ashoka’s Literature Department resonate well with this interpretation. For me, learning occurred not while marching towards a fixed destination but in deviations from the prescribed ‘path’. After graduating, in another deviation from the so-called ‘path’, I worked with the Govt. of Haryana and NITI Aayog on various skill development projects. The critical thinking, close reading, and writing skills I learned at Ashoka have helped me to grow not just in my work but also as a person. This Fall, I am heading to Oxford to begin my MPhil in Development Studies with the Department of International Development.”

Vibhuti Gour, ASP 2019,
M.Phil. Candidate, University of Oxford

“Studying English at Ashoka impacted, I would say, my entire career trajectory. While entering Ashoka I was all set to major in Economics, but I became enamoured with the warmth of the English faculty and the freshness of the subject. If not for Ashoka I’d probably have been a banker somewhere. Gives me the shivers, to even imagine it. But more than anything Ashoka gave me the space to do my own research and even do a little bit of teaching while I was an undergraduate, and that really helped me determine who I wanted to be as a scholar. I was supposed to fly out to Chicago in August 2020 for my PhD, but the Covid-19 Pandemic has compelled me to be content with online classes for at least the first quarter. Excited as I am to be in midnight zoom classes, I really can’t wait to be in a university again, learning, teaching, and researching. What after English? Quite simply, more English!”

Govind Narayan, ASP 2018
Ph.D. Candidate, Northwestern University

"The offerings of the English Department are a veritable smorgasbord. You get a variety of tastes and the chance to explore deeper and wider and make a meal of what appeals most to you. Who would have thought that you could go back to find new meanings in childhood stories or discover hidden gender messages in everyday Bollywood movies? These unique and exciting offerings are a far cry from what we are used to seeing on a traditional English Lit syllabus."

Geetanjali Chanda, Associate Professor of English
Ph.D. Hong Kong University

Children's Literature; Bollywood; Sikh writings and films; Women's writings;
Feminist and Transcultural pedagogy, Masculinities and Religion



"Calling literary study "knowledge on a holiday", the critic Michael Wood argues that literature "creates a new zone between work and play." Can the study or the practice of literature—or any of the arts—be professionalized? Or is it simply meant to enrich and deepen our amateur identity? This is the amateur as rooted not in ineptitude but in amour or love. These are some of the questions that intrigue me these days, and I hope you will find knowledge on a holiday no less rigorous than whatever it is the world gathers on its workdays."

Saikat Majumdar, Professor of English and Creative Writing,
Chair of the Department of English
Ph.D. Rutgers University

Modern and Contemporary World literatures; Modernism; Postcolonial
Studies; Novel and Narrative Theory; History of Criticism; Fiction writing



"Literature is a mode of thinking different from any other. I've spent my life as a writer trying to tease out, and argue for, this difference, and, when possible, to share my thoughts with my students."

Amit Chaudhuri, Professor of Creative Writing
Director of the Centre for the Creative and the Critical
D.Phil., Oxford University

Creative and Critical Writing; Contemporary literature; Literary Activism



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